

What is a Vision Quest?

A Vision Quest is a search for guidance, strength and purpose in life. It is a ceremony to celebrate a life transition, to deepen understanding, to connect with the spirit, and to find one's individual path.

With many societies using some form of wilderness solo to initiate young people in to adulthood, ceremonial rites of passage have been part of human society for thousands of years. These experiences are largely missing in our modern industrial culture. Without a clear threshold from the world of childhood into the world of the adult, many people in our culture never feel they have made this transition, no matter what their outer circumstances.

The Vision Quest experience empowers men, women and young adults to enact the age-old ceremonial pattern of symbolic death, of an old life, and rebirth in to the new. Modern life transitions may be release from addictions, recovery from childhood trauma, movement from one career to another, discovery of a life partner, realizing one's path on the earth, or developing connection to a Higher Power.

In creating a program designed for people of our time and place, we have taken the universal elements of rites of passage. As Vision Quest guides, we understand ourselves as midwives, rather than teachers. We feel we are assisting the birth process facilitated by nature, God, or whichever power you wish to name. Even though we have been involved in Native American medicine teachings, we do not define ourselves solely through those traditions. We are aware that our model of Vision Quest is a modern version of an ancient rite of passage that, in its bare bones, is common to indigenous peoples the world over.

The heart of the Vision Quest is a three-day solo, at a place the quester chooses. To prepare a participant for this process, pre-trip meetings are held in the month before departure for the wilderness. At these meetings, we present a wide range of information concerning the physical, psychological and spiritual dimensions of the quest. We explore the expectations and rationale of the prospective quester. What changes are taking place in a person's life? What are his/her gifts, and how can they bring them to the world? What are his/her fears, and how can they be used as tools for growth? These are some of the issues we discuss.

The wilderness portion of the experience takes a full week, with the Vision Quest solo taking place over three days and nights. The quester is encouraged to fast during this time, heightening awareness, and helping to develop spiritual openness. Events on the quest mirror and illuminate those of ordinary life. The wilderness provides many archetypal teachers. One discovers one's relations in the blooming cactus, the soft song of a bird, or the silence of a desert, or mountain, night.

The Vision Quester often returns full of inner strength and light, choosing to return to the wilderness of society, guided by the lessons learned from living close to the power of nature. The last day of our wilderness journey is spent in group council. As guides, we serve to mirror, integrate and empoweer each quester as they share the experience of their quest within the group.

The return from the quest can be a time of great energy and joy. Life is new; one has been reborn. But the reincorporation phase is a challenge. How does one bring new Vision back in to the world of work, relationship, and everyday life? We meet again for a reunion, in which the sharing of our experience deepens the understanding of our lessons, and their integration into our lives. The energy of the Vision Quest flows in to us as a healing, and from us, enters the world.